

# Father of the Bride

**Chiranjeevi's plans to join politics may have to wait as his image is dented following his daughter's elopement**

■ By Amarnath K. Menon

It's easy to see why celebrities act the way they do when their lives begin to resemble their movies. In countless films since he first faced the camera nearly 30 years ago, Telugu superstar Chiranjeevi has fought goons, villains and even family to walk away with the love of his life. Last week, it was the 52-year-old actor who was left stunned and speechless as his 19-year-old daughter Srijia defied her parents to marry an engineer Shirish Bharadwaj, 22, and then accused her father and family of attempting to hound them into annulling the marriage.

The young couple's fears weren't entirely misplaced. Some years back, Chiranjeevi's brothers had plotted to break off the engagement of his elder daughter Sushmita with an upcoming movie star Uday Kiran. The newlyweds, anticipating trouble, including the arrest of Bharadwaj on trumped-up charges and a backlash from Chiranjeevi's fans, fled Hyderabad by road, changing at least six cars to surface in Delhi seeking police protection.

In Delhi, their lawyer Pinky Anand told the high court that if it did not intervene, her clients might meet the same fate as Rizwanur Rahman, the Kolkata graphic designer who was allegedly murdered by his well-con-



**FAMILY STRAINS:** Srijia and Shirish; Chiranjeevi (below); Kalyan (R)



nected in-laws. Justice S.N. Dingra directed the Delhi Police to provide them protection until October 29 and wait for further orders. He also asked Chiranjeevi to appear in court and give his consent to the marriage.

The court's intervention came after a fervent public appeal by Chiranjeevi asking his daughter to return home—through a homemade video aired by television channels—which fell on deaf ears. "Sweetie, your happiness is our happiness," he made it abundantly clear in a forgive-and-forget mode. Giving the row yet another theatrical twist, Pawan Kalyan, the actor-brother of Chiranjeevi, who was opposed to the Bharadwaj-Srijia wedding, deposited his revolver at a police station in a symbolic conciliatory gesture that they had no ill will against the newlyweds.

However, all this did not cut any ice with the adamant couple and they appeared on primetime television in the capital, where an anchor of a chan-

**"Her sudden decision has shocked all of our family members."**

CHIRANJEEVI, ACTOR